

An Essay About Interdependence

~ *Relationship of Independence with Interdependence. Oh, There's a Whale, Too.*

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Independence is a theory. Interdependence is a practice. Solidarity is difficult to understand.

In this brief essay, I first delineate examples of independence as an American ideal evident in the country's early formative literature. Next, I assert that interdependence, not independence, is a practical reality of American life. Then, I identify four episodes in *Moby-Dick*, Herman Melville's epic novel, that demonstrate the ambiguous pretexts to human interdependence and solidarity. Also attached is an appendix that reports my long experience stalking *Moby-Dick*.

INDEPENDENCE IS AN AMERICAN IDEAL

Independence in thought and action is not a uniquely American ideal. Many societies value personal initiative, self-reliance, freedom of judgment, and individual responsibility. But American culture prizes it with unusual intensity. Most distinctly American, though, is the treatment of independence as a central moral belief and necessity—sometimes even as a mark of maturity, character, or citizenship.

Some American writings, especially those published during the country's formative years, are enduring testaments to independence. In *Luck and Pluck*, a serial story by Horatio Alger Jr., a boy is depicted who pulls himself up by his bootstraps after his father's death through perseverance, hard work, and struggle. Ralph Waldo Emerson models this ideal in *Self-Reliance*, urging readers to trust themselves, resist conformity, and think independently. Emerson asserts that "Man is his own star."

In *Walden*, Henry David Thoreau extends Emerson's ideal by treating self-sufficiency, simplicity, and independence of mind as moral goods. Thoreau argues further in *Civil Disobedience* that individual conscience must stand above unjust law. To Thoreau, dissent from orthodoxy and resistance to conformity are moral duties.

In *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, Mark Twain dramatizes this same commitment to independence when Huck chooses to follow his own conscience rather than the moral assumptions of the society around him. Walt Whitman's *Song of Myself* similarly celebrates the self, personal freedom, and independent identity as bold, democratic, and spiritually significant. He writes, "I celebrate myself, and sing myself....I harbor...nature without check with original energy."

American culture has long celebrated and revered the independence in thought and action represented in these writings, not just independence among individuals but by our communities and nation.

INTERDEPENDENCE IS A HUMAN PRACTICE, THOUGH

Independence alone is just not enough. The deeper truth is that we are bound up with one another. When treated as absolutes, individualism and self-reliance can dull our empathy, feed the pride that ripens into hubris, and weaken the solidarity on which shared life depends. Without meaningful ties to others, we risk becoming strangers even to our own humanity. Interdependence is practical.

Our well-being is not ours alone but shared. We forge family ties, nurture friendships, help our neighbors, stay civil, and build trade and peace among nations. Not just to reduce friction in everyday transactions. But also to answer a deep and persistent human longing for growth, wholeness, and greater purpose. Interdependence is not only practical but noble.

The interdependence on which life itself depends is ever on loan to us. Its value lies in the common good it can achieve. Yet its value also rests on its frailty, with how easily it is wounded, and on how quickly it can slip away. Interdependence is not only practical and noble but also fragile.

Why do we depend on others at all? Why risk so much on other people? Why build our lives around bonds that can disappoint, wound, or fail us? Even the most ordinary acts of interdependence arise from motives that are mixed and hard to name. Are we acting out of generosity, or out of self-protection? Is virtue at work here, or fear? Is interdependence a genuine moral practice or a form of prudent insurance? So wherever it appears—between persons, within communities, among nations—interdependence proves to be not only practical, noble, and fragile, but also complex.

Reflections on our interdependence can stir visible emotion—smiles, tears of joy, applause. They can also awaken deeper feelings of belonging, an awareness of

shared needs, and humbling recognitions of our limits. Shared dependence can give people, communities, and nations comfort, moral confidence, and a sense of duty fulfilled.

Yet interdependence has a grittier side. For understanding that side, it is worth turning to Herman Melville.

HERMAN MELVILLE'S GRITTY INTERDEPENDENCE

Herman Melville was an American writer during the American Renaissance, a period in literature that ran from about 1830 to around the Civil War (1861–65). *Moby-Dick* is his most famous book.* The moral importance of Melville's book lies in its portrayal of the dangers of hubris and obsession, its demonstration of the limits of human power, and its identification of the nature of shared humanity. *Moby-Dick* offers a platform for discussing the nuances of interdependence and the nature of solidarity.

Abstract of Moby-Dick

Here, after stripping away the brine and blubber from the book, is my abstract of *Moby-Dick*:

Moby-Dick is what happens when one man's inability to let things go becomes everybody else's problem. Captain Ahab decides that ordinary revenge is not enough. He will chase the whale that severed his leg to the ends of the earth and take his whaling ship, the *Pequod*, with him. Ishmael, a harpooner who signs on for what he presumes will be a rugged but manageable maritime job, instead finds himself trapped in a floating manifestation of all-consuming obsession. Around him is a memorable crew—Queequeg, Starbuck, and a host of others with names of biblical origin—who, for various reasons ranging from greed to loyalty to sheer bad luck, keep going along with this increasingly terrible plan. Ahab grows steadily less interested in profit, reason, or the opinions of anyone trying to save him from himself. By the time he smashes the *Pequod*'s navigational instruments and rages against the universe, the voyage ceases to be a business venture and spirals away from reason and reality. The chase ends, unsurprisingly, very badly. *Moby-Dick* wins, the *Pequod* goes down to the deep, and only Ishmael survives, clinging to Queequeg's coffin and left to tell a story about revenge, fate, and the danger of human pride run wild.

* I had my own epic journey with Herman Melville and *Moby-Dick* that I summarize in an appendix, "My Experience Stalking *Moby-Dick* and the White Whale's Fury With Me."

Four Passages Showing a Gritty Form of Interdependence

Melville creates tension in *Moby-Dick* by first agreeing that our well-being depends on others. But then he makes that dependence a terrifying vulnerability, not a warm safety net.

Melville describes the flung-together crew of the Pequod as “isolatoes” arriving on the Pequod in a desolation of solitude and alienation, “not acknowledging the common continent of men, but each isolato living on a separate continent of his own.” Different, but thrown together like soldiers battling in the same campaign.

The isolatoes work long hours daily physically close to, as Melville writes, “Squeeze! Squeeze! Squeeze!” whale oil from blubber until they are “almost melted into it...A strange sort of insanity came over me; and I found myself unwittingly squeezing my co-laborers’ hands in it, mistaking their hands for the gentle globules.”

Their connections aboard the Pequod force them together in ways that would never have happened on land. The crew of the Pequod is highly diverse, representing various regions and ethnic backgrounds, including sailors from the U.S., Peru, Isle of Man, France, West Africa, the islands of the South Pacific, Iceland, China, and many others. In fact, this diversity brought together diverse skills and perspectives, enhancing their ability to work together.

Sailing the Pequod requires teamwork. Whaling expeditions are strenuous and dangerous. Whalers face injury and death from storms and rough seas, capsizing of small boats dragged by harpooned whales, falling from rigging, slipping on decks, malfunctioning of nautical equipment, and violent encounters with whales that attacked boats or crew members. Some whaling expeditions lost over one-third of their crews.

Whaling has been described as “an extraordinarily primal, existential confrontation between human beings and what was really the last frontier of untamed nature.” Ahab tells his crew that, when they set off in a small boat to harpoon a whale, the outcomes are starkly binary: “A dead whale or a stove [wrecked] boat!”

The proximity, shared toil, and, in some cases, friendship among the crew of the Pequod supported and balanced their workloads. As in the official song of the U.S. Merchant Marine, “My lads, heave ho! It's a long, long way to go. It's a long, long pull with our hatches full, braving the wind, braving the sea, fighting the treacherous foe.” However, a special, gritty interdependence is evident in some

instances of danger and disaster, which often occur aboard the Pequod and lead to its complete destruction and the loss of its crew, save for Ishmael.

I extracted four scenes from *Moby-Dick* that demonstrate a gritty interdependence that Melville drives his characters to embody and, in the end, suffer for. I will call these scenes: the “monkey-rope” episode; the “democratic” hell of the Pequod; Queequeg’s rescue of the greenhand; and the final wreck. These scenes show interdependence in a gritty, organic way because the crew shows solidarity spontaneously, with nothing other than shared humanity compelling one person to connect with another.

The "Monkey-Rope" Episode

The episode is drawn from Chapter 72, titled "The Monkey-Rope." Queequeg must descend from the ship’s deck onto a whale's back to dissect a catch before it is brought aboard the Pequod. Ishmael holds him by a rope “attached to a strong strip of canvas belted round his [Ishmael’s] waist.” Ishmael and Queequeg are tied so that if Queequeg slips while harpooning, Ishmael gets dragged under the waves, too. “An elongated Siamese ligature united us. Queequeg was my own inseparable twin brother; nor could I any way get rid of the dangerous liabilities which the hempen bond entails.”

Ishmael panics, realizing his life is literally in another's hands. He reflects: “So strongly and metaphysically did I conceive of my situation then... I seemed distinctly to perceive that my own individuality was now merged in a joint stock company of two: that my free will had received a mortal wound; and that another’s mistake or misfortune might plunge innocent me into unmerited disaster and death.” Well-being here is mutual hostage-taking—you cannot thrive without trust, but trust might kill you.

Ishmael observes that this is "the precise situation of every mortal that breathes... If your banker breaks, you snap; if your apothecary by mistake sends you poison in your pills, you die.” Sharks are also a present danger: “Right in among those sharks was Queequeg,” and, as two other whalers wield whale-cutting spades overhead, Ishmael fears for Queequeg’s safety. “Those indiscreet spades of theirs would come nearer amputating a leg than a tail,” he thinks.

There is no romance in the rope between Ishmael and Queequeg. Teamwork is sweaty, anxious, and utterly involuntary. Melville forces us to admit that our physical survival—our most basic well-being—rests on the steadiness of another person's hand. We like to believe we are self-sufficient individuals, but on the

deck of the Pequod, that fiction dissolves by salt spray. Dependence is not a choice; it is a condition to stay alive.

The “Democratic” Hell of the Pequod

A tension plays out in the long thematic arc that runs throughout the Pequod’s voyage. On one hand, Captain Ahab is a totalitarian, tyrannical figure. He wields uncompromised power. He is laser-focused on revenge against the white whale that severed his leg. His maniacal dictatorship leads the ship to ruin. On the other hand, the diverse crew of the Pequod embodies a democratic spirit fed by shared motivations, experiences, and hardships.

The crew of the Pequod shares food and water and sleeps in hammocks hung in common, cramped quarters. They are intertwined by the mundane necessities of shipboard life. Their interdependence is vulnerable to the madness of one man. Every crewman depends on Ahab for wages and direction and lives in his grip.

Their dependence on Ahab delivers them to the bottom of the sea. The group drowns together, even when no individual wishes to perish. Melville makes a brutal point. Interdependence makes no guarantee. Most of those drowned lived democratically—but in a “democratic” hell.

Queequeg’s Rescue of the Greenhand

Early in the voyage of the Pequod (in Chapter 13), a greenhand, an inexperienced sailor, is swept overboard in a flash during a squall. Queequeg had rough, angry words with the greenhand right before the accident. Still, Queequeg dives after him without a second thought. “Queequeg, stripped to the waist, darted from the side with a long living arc of a leap... Dived down and disappeared... he rose again, one arm still striking out, and with the other dragging a lifeless form.” Following this, Ishmael reports, “All hands voted Queequeg a noble trump.”

Queequeg does not calculate the risk. He does not weigh the situation through the lens of an abstract moral philosophy. He just does it based on what Melville calls “the mystical vibration” of common humanity. The greenhorn is not saved by laws, contracts, or careful planning, but by an unthinking act of human connection between two sailors who barely know one another.

The greenhand lives because a stranger chooses to leap, not because of a system or a divine guarantee, but only because of the chaotic generosity of a man who owes him nothing. Interdependence sparks incautiously without much forethought.

The Final Wreck

The Epilogue to *Moby-Dick* recounts the sinking of the Pequod and Ishmael's rescue. After the Pequod sinks, Queequeg's empty coffin splashes up from the depths. Ishmael floats to safety holding to the coffin that Queequeg had built for himself and later carved with tribal markings. Queequeg, obviously lost, does not send it to him. The laws of physics hoist the coffin, less dense than water, to the surface in proximity to Ishmael. Fortunate. But, impromptu.

Everyone else perishes. The sea does not care that they were teammates and interdependent. It swallows all but one of the whole crew indiscriminately. The Rachel, another whaling ship, plucks Ishmael from the sea. "On the second day, a sail drew near, nearer, and picked me up at last. It was the devious-cruising Rachel, that in her retracing search after her missing children, only found another orphan."

Ishmael's dependence on Queequeg was never planned, never decided between them, never set in a will. Ishmael's life depended on a random collision between his good fortune and Queequeg's loss. Melville did not frame interdependence as a celebration. He framed it as a miracle *and* a tragedy.

THE MORAL OF THIS FABLE

Independence is a compelling ideal, but interdependence is our practical reality. Although interdependence fosters essential solidarity among people, communities, and nations, Melville reveals a darker truth: our interconnectedness is often random, circumstantial, and highly vulnerable. A single person, community, or nation with unchecked power can sabotage it entirely. Ultimately, this leaves us with both a lesson and a warning: solidarity is deeply nuanced, bound together by tenuous social, political, and economic connections that demand our constant vigilance.

Appendix:

MY EXPERIENCE STALKING *MOBY-DICK* AND THE WHITE WHALE'S FURY WITH ME

I stalked *Moby-Dick*, the book, like Ahab stalked the White Whale. The difference is that Ahab died in the process, and I feel, as I write this, still alive. At the end of the book, *Moby-Dick* continued to roam the seas.

I write here, in Melville fashion, a brief aside about my long hunt for *Moby-Dick*.

First Brush

Did you read *Moby-Dick*? All of it? All at once? Herman Melville's 1851 epic is considered a cornerstone of American literature. But at over 206,000 or so words, depending on whether you count the prologue, 135 chapter titles, and epilogue, it can feel less like reading a novel than signing on for an ocean voyage stuck in the Strait of Hormuz during war. Google Search coaches me that I could read *Moby-Dick* in "15 to 20 hours," or "about 2 to 3 weeks, if you read an hour a day." Now, that's a clear lie and, for me, a fat chance.

When I was a first-year undergraduate, *Moby-Dick* bogged me down with its nautical and whaling terms. Directional words for a ship's layout like "aback," "abeam," "afoul," and "abaft" confused me so much that I lost the confidence to step into a bathtub. Whale butchering, I found, produces "gurry" (guts and visceral trimmings) and yields "slobgollion" (an oozy, stringy substance rung from the brains of Sperm Whales).

Then there's the plot drifting through the eddies of Melville's sprawling prose. At times, the story moves so slowly that I felt trapped in a skid-row bar listening to a sodden old sailor gibble-gabble about the sacred lore of knot-tying, the ravages of scurvy, the benefits of owning a good pair of boots, scrimshawing, or the symptoms of gonorrhea. Once you are in, you can't get out.

Melville's style is ornate and uninhibited, as if directness is no rule in his writing style manual. In the opening chapter, the narrator—who states we should call him Ishmael—says, "I thought I would sail about a little and see the watery part of the world. It is a way I have of driving off the spleen and regulating the circulation." Your undergraduate reader concluded that Ishmael used too many words to say he simply needed a vacation.

The text is salt-stained with minutiae. In Chapter 80, Melville details the complex skull anatomy of the Sperm Whale ("phrenologically the head of this Leviathan,

in the creature's living intact state, is an entire delusion"). Chapter 32 is titled "Cetology," the zoological classification of whales. Chapters 74 and 75 contrast the physical characteristics of the heads of the Sperm Whale and Baleen Whale. Did I mention that there are 135 chapters and more?

Then come *Moby-Dick's* biblical allusions and hidden cultural symbols—the shiny gems we were urged to mine from *Silas Marner*, *The Scarlet Letter*, or *Lord of the Flies*...to get ready for college, we were told. We were told to uncover "complex themes," "rich language and philosophic substance," "dense, layered metaphors," and to practice "extracting themes" and "naming symbols." Perhaps to prepare later to ascend *Moby-Dick*, I suppose. All jibber-jabber to the immature teen brain that sorts this stuff in hallways before the lunch bell rings.

Beyond these impediments to digesting Melville's prose, I was starting to feel restrained. Even though I had given *Moby-Dick* a go for four days (well, parts of them, actually), I noticed myself aging rapidly. I was spending too much of my free college boy time in the library. Beer must be drunk, you know.

One day I stared out a window from a library desk where Melville's tome was rudely staring, in turn, at me. I paid it no mind. I saw my friend talking to a girl. I decided to complain to my literature professor. He lit a Camel Turkish Gold, looked straight ahead at the faculty parking lot, and said, "College life is busy."

One More Time

Well, I eventually read *Moby-Dick* again, this time presented to me in a thick, bulky, heavily annotated edition, reading it episodically over several months in my thirties, while filling in the gaps between life as a father and as a young professor. I was a full-grown man with a graduate degree. I had to try again. I felt obligated. I had something to prove. My own whale to harpoon. So, I paid attention. I wrote notes, some of which I recently found stuffed into a folder in my closet. I scarcely recognize them. My mother always warned me about the consequences of my bad penmanship.

More recently, I listened to a 23-hour recording of *Moby-Dick* over the course of a week. Ah, yes, I recommend this approach without reservation to those of you who reach the age of 79 as well. You hear the poetry. You soak in the details. Long, discursive sentences are also how you talk now, right?

It's just you and your AirPods. No straining to hear tweedy English professors mumble with non-rhotic pronunciation while facing chalkboards. You won't

stumble upon a word that compels you to wander down dictionary paths to find “related words” or through forests of interesting encyclopedia entries “for more thorough insights.”

Of course, you must stay awake while *Moby-Dick* is read to you, but all you have at this age is the fullness of time and a rewind button.